provincial administration there. Ashoka was evidently the legatee of Chandragupta's spoils and administrative system.

If the political governors of Mauryan kings were based in the region, what had made them choose Junagadh as their provincial capital? This is hard to say for certain, but one reason will have been the naturally defensive neighbourhood of Junagadh. The area was forested and hill-girt, with the highest mountain in Gujarat, the Gorakhnath summit, located at Girnar. The hilly areas of Kathiawar district were relatively secure, causing many towns to come up over the centuries, including Adityana, Mendarda, Talala, and Visavadar.[6] Junagadh's access to the coast must have been another important factor. The ocean is less than 80 km from here and from Girnar a glimpse is sometimes possible of forests and low hills that run in a continuous sweep to the sea. Tod, having ascended the summit of the seven-peaked Girnar, marvelled at having seen 'the ocean lighted up by the sun's last rays, while silence ruled over the remains of fading glory.'[7]

The provincial governor, in all likelihood, administered the entire territory from the Junagadh hills to the Arabian Sea. There was a Mauryan settlement at Prabhas Patan, not far from the temple site of Somnath, which means the Mauryas ruled a swathe from Girnar to the south-west coast of Saurashtra. Situated on the right bank of the Hiran river, Prabhas Patan was a port which regulated trade and traffic to and from the hinterland. If Junagadh's location was naturally secure because of the hills, Prabhas Patan was made secure by the creation of a fortified core. The time period contemporary with the Mauryas (Period IV which stretches from the fourth till the first century BCE) saw the creation of a stone citadel, with the wall marked by bastions at cardinal points.[8] The creation of this kind of town in Saurashtra continued well into modern times, with eighteenth-century urban centres here being primarily military fortresses.[9]

The other aspect of Junagadh which comes alive thanks to inscriptional allusions to the construction of a dam by the Mauryan state in the time of